

Inclusive gender in Spanish

Subverting the heteronormative taxonomy by expressive means

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Abstract. This paper discusses the linguistic implications of the inclusive gender strategy in Spanish. The core thesis is that inclusive gender consists of a form of expressive manipulation in Corver's (2016) sense, i.e., deviation of rules of grammar. Yet, the strategy directly impacts on representation, not only on expressivity, by subverting the type of heteronormative taxonomy that can be inferred from the current gender system. Concretely, by adding the new gender morpheme *-e*, the rule of restricted Human Cloning (a version of Harris' 1991 original rule), which creates [male] and [female] nominal oppositions in DPs denoting atomic entities, is excluded from the system. I also compare the inclusive strategy with another strategy of linguistic intervention, namely, slur reappropriation, i.e., the use of slur words by members of the target of derogation. The two strategies contrast in several respects. For instance, whereas the inclusive strategy manipulates (anti-)presuppositions to restrict the masculine form to less contexts of use, reclamation manipulates use-conditional meanings to give the slur word more, not less, contexts of use.

Key words: inclusive gender, anti-presuppositions, semantic markedness, slur reclamation, Spanish

1. Introduction

Gender in Spanish can be characterized through three very general properties (see Estomba 2016). First, there are good reasons to conceive of the gender inflectional paradigm in Spanish as a dual system¹, in which gender is encoded only in two ways, namely (i) either a noun/pronoun is feminine, or (ii) is "masculine". Second, we say that the system is *exhaustive* in the sense that every relevant noun/pronoun must encode the feminine or the "masculine" regardless of the semantic class of the nominal category. Finally, the system is *semi-predictable*, i.e., for a subset of the categories in the nominal class its gender can be determined on the basis of its semantic class. Thus, for almost all human nouns/pronouns, if the noun is marked as 'female', then it is [feminine] (Harris 1991).

The current gender system in human nouns (toy sample):

human nouns:

- (1) a. niño 'child.M.SG' b. niña 'child.F.SG'
c. niños 'child.M.PL' c. niñas 'child.F.PL'

definite articles:

- (2) a. el 'ART.M.SG' b. la 'ART.F.SG'
c. los 'ART.M.PL' c. las 'ART.F.PL'

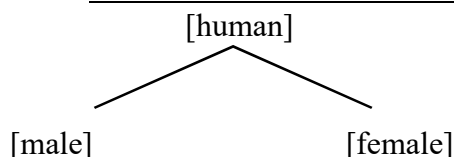
- (3) personal pronouns

- a. él 'he' b. ella 'she'
c. ellos 'they.M.PL' d. ellas 'they.F.PL'

¹ This way of looking at the current system denies the existence of the so-called *neuter* as a third gender (e.g., *lo lindo* 'the nice', *ello* 'it'; see Bosque and Moreno 1990 for an in-depth study and Saab 2017 for an argument against the existence of the neuter as a third gender). This contrasts with languages in which there is true neuter gender like, say, Greek (see Adamson and Anagnostopoulou 2024 for a very recent analysis on gender resolution in three-gendered languages).

No doubt: for the case of human nouns, in which there is a syntactic-semantic correlation between gender and sex, a certain heteronormative taxonomy can be inferred:

(4) The heteronormative taxonomy:



[I.e., human nouns are either male or female]

This taxonomy is under dispute in the public debate in many Spanish-speaking countries/cities. A first relevant question in this debate is whether the Spanish gender system is (representationally) biased, i.e., in the sense of placing the speaker into a particular (gender-biased / oppressive) *cultural / ideological dimension* (in the Bakhtinian's sense). I don't know (perhaps), but for some, it is (see section 4 for some discussion). The problem is not only the heteronormativity of the system. There is another dimension of this putative bias having to do with the fact that the distribution of the feminine and the "masculine" is not uniform, since the "masculine" is used in more contexts than the feminine. There is what I will call the "unwanted rules":

(5) The "unwanted" rules (simplified): use the "masculine" form in plurals referring to mixed-groups or in singular generics.

Here are a couple of relevant examples:

(6) Plurals (for mixed groups):

- | | | | | |
|----|------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|---------------|
| a. | <i>Los</i> | <i>niños</i> | <i>llegaron</i> | <i>tarde.</i> |
| | ART.M.PL | child.M.PL | arrived | late |
| | 'The children arrived late.' | | | |
| b. | <i>Ellos</i> | <i>llegaron</i> | <i>tarde.</i> | |
| | they.M.PL | arrived | late | |
| | 'They arrived late.' | | | |

(7) Singular generics:

- | | | |
|---|-------------|--------------------|
| Usualmente, <i>el</i> | <i>niño</i> | <i>habla solo.</i> |
| usually | ART.M.SG | child.M.SG |
| | | speaks alone.M.SG |
| 'Usually, the child speaks alone/to himself.' | | |

For the proponents of the inclusive strategy, the unwanted rules are gender-biased, and then, a concrete instance of biased grammar in the favored sense (i.e., in the sense of placing the speaker into a particular cultural setting). A way of avoiding at the same time both the heteronormative bias and the unwanted rules is by giving up the dual character of the current system. Here is a proposal, according to which a third gender morpheme, the so-called "inclusive" one, is added into the system:

One of the proposed "inclusive" gender systems:

(8) human nouns:

- | | | |
|------------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| a. <i>niño</i> 'child.M.SG' | b. <i>niña</i> 'child.F.SG' | c. <i>niñe</i> 'ART.INCLUSIVE.SG' |
| d. <i>niños</i> 'child.M.PL' | e. <i>niñas</i> 'child.F.PL' | f. <i>niñes</i> 'child.INCLUSIVE.PL' |

- (9) definite articles:
- | | | |
|-------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|
| a. el ‘ART.M.SG’ | b. la ‘ART.F.SG’ | c. <u>le</u> ‘ART.INCLUSIVE.SG’ |
| d. los ‘ART.M.PL’ | e. las ‘ART.F.PL’ | d. <u>les</u> ‘ART.INCLUSIVE.PL’ |
- (10) personal pronouns
- | | | |
|----------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------|
| a. él ‘he’ | b. ella ‘she’ | c. <u>elle</u> ‘PR.INCLUSIVE.SG’ |
| d. ellos ‘they.M.PL’ | e. ellas ‘they.M.PL’ | f. <u>elles</u> ‘PR.INCLUSIVE.PL’ |

The inclusive morpheme, then, replace the “masculine” one in mixed and generic environments, as illustrated below:

- (11) Plurals (for mixed groups):
- | | | | | |
|----|--|-----------------|-----------------|---------------|
| a. | <i>Les</i> | <i>niñes</i> | <i>llegaron</i> | <i>tarde.</i> |
| | ART.INCL.PL | child.INCL.PL | arrived | late |
| | ‘The children (no gender) arrived late.’ | | | |
| b. | <i>Elles</i> | <i>llegaron</i> | <i>tarde.</i> | |
| | they.INCL.PL | arrived | late | |
| | ‘They arrived late.’ | | | |
- (12) Singular generics:
- | | | | | |
|--|-------------|---------------|----------------------|--------------|
| Usualmente, | <i>le</i> | <i>niñe</i> | <i>habla</i> | <i>sole.</i> |
| usually | ART.INCL.SG | child.INCL.SG | speaks alone.INCL.SG | |
| ‘Usually, the child speaks alone/to themself.’ | | | | |

From a formal perspective on the morphosemantic resolution of Spanish gender, this opens another relevant question, namely, what exactly does the inclusive linguistic behavior consist of in morphosemantics terms? Answering this question in a reasonable way should contribute to a better understanding of the question on gender bias stated above. Here I would like to offer and defend the following thesis:

- (13) Thesis on inclusive language: Inclusive language is a concrete instance of expressive manipulation in Corver’s (2016) sense (i.e., deviation from rules of grammar). Yet, unlike Corver’s expectations, grammatical deviation in this case also impacts on representation (connected to propositional/thought systems).

According to Corver, emotion/expressivity in language sometimes results from certain specific manipulations of the rules of grammar, which essentially impact on the appraisal system, a cognitive system modeled in terms of valences. The thesis in (13) partially aligns with this idea although it adds the claim that representation can also be altered by expressive means. I am aware that this makes the dividing line between representation and expression subtle (to say the least). Schematically, the core idea is that inclusive manipulations into the gender system turn the taxonomy in (4) into the following one, in which there is no necessary connection between the feature [human] and the gender features [male] or [female]:

- (14) The new taxonomy (a plausible description):
- ```

graph TD
 A["[human]"] --- B["([male])"]
 A --- C["([female])"]

```

[I.e., you don't need associate human nouns to [male] or [female]]

Now, one must agree that there is no way to evaluate the thesis in (13) without a good understanding of the current system. This leads to the third core question regarding how the current taxonomy in (4) is derived in the Spanish gender system. Let me summarize these initial considerations through the following three core questions:

(Q1) Is the Spanish gender system (representationally) biased?

[I.e., in the sense of placing the speaker into a particular (gender-biased / oppressive) *cultural / ideological dimension* (in the Bajtinian's sense)?]

(Q2) What exactly does the inclusive linguistic behavior consist of?

(Q3) How is the heteronormative taxonomy derived in the current gender system?

In what follows, I offer some thoughts on (inclusive) gender with the aim of providing some preliminary answers to Q2 and Q3. In section 2, I offer some background discussion on the semantics and pragmatics of the current gender system, particularly addressing the question whether the actual system has [male] feature encoded in grammar. If not, then it seems that the dual character of the system can be derived by familiar anti-presuppositional reasoning (Sauerland 2002, 2008a,b, Percus 2006). Yet, empirically, the system does encode a [male] property in some specific environments, a fact that makes a proper analysis of the gender system harder. Additional evidence for a [human] feature is also discussed in the same section. In section 3, I focus on the thesis in (13), according to which inclusive language is a case of expressive manipulation. This manipulation is morphosemantic in the sense that it directly affects both the morphological resolution of gender and its semantics. In the concluding section, I summarize the results and discuss slur reclamation. A brief comparison between both the inclusive gender and the slur reclamation strategies is particularly enlightening both from a purely linguistic perspective and from a sociolinguistic one. As we will see, it seems that slurs reclamation can be essentially reduced to a pragmatic intention to enlarge contexts the use. If successful, the strategy has anti-bias character. In contrast, inclusive gender reduces contexts the use of the [male] property through semantically marking it.

## **2. Semantics and pragmatics of the current gender system**

In this section, I focus on the proper morphosemantic analysis of the current gender system to provide an initial answer to Q3:

(Q3) How is the heteronormative taxonomy derived in the current gender system?

The current consensus points out to the conclusion that the gender system is morphologically and semantically marked for [feminine] and [female], respectively. Yet, it is not clear whether the system also encodes a [male] semantic feature in some specific grammatical environments. If this is the case, then it would impact on our considerations about what exactly the inclusive strategy behavior consists of. I argue here that the system does encode [male] feature in some restricted context and discuss the consequences of this fact for the proper characterization of gender in Spanish.

### *2.1. Gender (anti-)presuppositions: is there a [male] feature in the system?*

Here is a first important observation regarding human nouns in Spanish:

- (15) Mating: Human nouns are “mated”, both a masculine and a feminine form exist for each human noun.

[Harris 1991: 37]

This is true regardless of gender realization, i.e., the observation covers any noun class, even suppletive pairs:

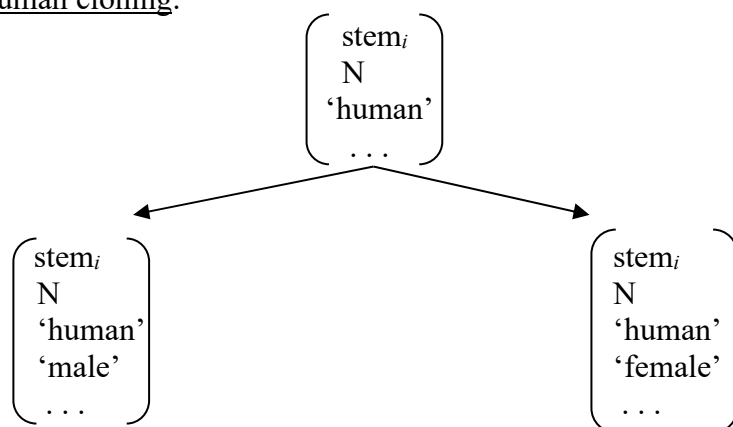
- (16) *Sex related pairs (including human ‘honoris causa’)*
- |     |                           |                  |                           |
|-----|---------------------------|------------------|---------------------------|
|     | <i>Masculine (class1)</i> |                  | <i>Feminine (class 2)</i> |
| (a) | hermano ‘brother’         | hermana ‘sister’ |                           |
|     | hijo ‘son’                | hija ‘daughter’  |                           |
|     | niño ‘boy’                | niña ‘girl’      |                           |
|     | esposo ‘husband’          | esposa ‘wife’    |                           |
|     | tío ‘uncle’               | tía ‘aunt’       |                           |
|     | muchacho ‘boy’            | muchacha ‘girl’  |                           |
|     | gato ‘cat’                | gata ‘cat’       |                           |
|     | perro ‘dog’               | perra ‘bitch’    |                           |
|     | burro ‘donkey’            | burra ‘donkey’   |                           |
- 
- |     |                |             |                |
|-----|----------------|-------------|----------------|
|     | <i>Class 3</i> |             | <i>Class 2</i> |
| (b) | jefe ‘boss’    | jefa ‘boss’ |                |
|     | monje ‘monk’   | monja ‘nun’ |                |
|     | nene ‘baby’    | nena ‘baby’ |                |
- 
- (c) *Invariable nouns*  
(el ‘the.M.SG’/la ‘the.F.SG’)
- |            |           |
|------------|-----------|
| testigo    | ‘witness’ |
| mártir     | ‘martyr’  |
| estudiante | ‘student’ |
| dentista   | ‘dentist’ |
| patriota   | ‘patriot’ |
- 
- Other suffixes*
- |                  |  |                   |
|------------------|--|-------------------|
| <i>Masculine</i> |  | <i>Feminine</i>   |
| (d) duque ‘duke’ |  | duquesa ‘duchess’ |
| zar ‘czar’       |  | zarina ‘czarina’  |
| poeta ‘poet’     |  | poetisa ‘poet’    |
| gallo ‘cock’     |  | gallina ‘hen’     |
- 
- Suppletive Pairs*
- |                     |  |                         |
|---------------------|--|-------------------------|
| <i>Masculine</i>    |  | <i>Feminine</i>         |
| (e) caballo ‘horse’ |  | yegua ‘mare’            |
| macho ‘male’        |  | hembra ‘female’         |
| yerno ‘son-in-law’  |  | nuera ‘daughter-in-law’ |
| toro ‘bull’         |  | vaca ‘cow’              |
| hombre ‘man’        |  | mujer ‘woman’           |
| padre ‘father’      |  | madre ‘mother’          |
| papá ‘dad’          |  | mamá ‘mum’              |

For Harris, one needs only two rules to explain mating and gender resolution. There is a rule of gender resolution that redundantly assigns the feature [feminine] to any female human noun

(see (17a)). Now, human nouns are divided in [female] and [male] through a lexical rule dubbed *human cloning* by Harris (see (17b)):

- (17) a. Human gender:  
‘female’ → f / [\_\_\_\_, ‘human’]

- b. Human cloning:



[Harris 1991: 51]

In Harris' own words:<sup>2</sup>

*The effect of Human Cloning is this: for every lexical entry L of a noun stem that contains the semantic specification 'human' without specification of sex, Human Cloning replaces L with a pair of entries L<sub>m</sub> and L<sub>f</sub>, each identical to L except for the addition of the semantic specifications, 'male' and 'female', respectively.*

[Harris 1991: 51]

The two core ingredients in Harris' analysis can be summarized as follows: (i) the gender system is marked for feminine (privatively under his analysis), (ii) reference to sex in human nouns constitutes an equipollent opposition, i.e., the system is semantically unmarked and symmetric. This second ingredient leads to an obvious problem when it comes to explaining the “unwanted rules”. Let me generalize (5) including many of the environments in which markedness effects are observed:

- (18) The “unwanted” rules: In the following environments, use the “masculine” form whenever you want to refer to mixed groups or to block any sex distinction,
- plural DPs,
  - generic DPs
  - DPs headed by generalized quantifiers

<sup>2</sup> According to Harris, there are only four exceptions (see (i)), but perhaps only *persona* deserves some serious consideration (*gente* ‘people’ and *pueblo* ‘folks’ are interesting but not clear exceptions). For Harris, *persona*, *víctima* and *criatura* “whose meaning has no component referring to sex, have lexical entries that contain a specification for (feminine) gender” (p. 52).

|     |           |           |                  |
|-----|-----------|-----------|------------------|
| (i) | MASCULINE |           | FEMININE         |
|     | marido    | ‘husband’ | *marida ‘wife’   |
|     | *criaturo |           | criatura ‘baby’  |
|     | *persono  |           | persona ‘person’ |
|     | *víctimo  |           | víctima ‘victim’ |

- d. DPs headed by numerals
- e. unspecific definite descriptions headed by the definite article

Here is a list of relevant examples:

(19) Plurals (for mixed groups):

- a. *Los niños* llegaron tarde.  
ART.M.PL child.M.PL arrived late  
'The children arrived late.'
- b. *Ellos* llegaron tarde.  
they.M.PL arrived late  
'They arrived late.'

(20) Singular generics (no sex distinction):

- Usualmente, *el niño* habla solo.  
usually ART.M.SG child.M.SG speaks alone.M.SG  
'Usually, the child speaks alone/to himself.'

Non-inflected quantifiers:

- (21) a. *Cada alumno* debe presentar una monografía.  
each student.M.SG must present a monograph  
'Each student must present a monograph.'
- b. *Todo alumno* debe presentar una monografía.  
every student.M.SG must present a monograph  
'Every student must present a monograph.'

Inflected quantifiers:

- (22) a. *Algún alumno* llegó tarde.  
some.M.SG student.M.SG arrived late  
'Some student arrived late.'
- b. *Algunos alumnos* llegaron tarde.  
some.M.PL student.M.PL arrived late  
'Some students arrived late.'

(the same with *ningún estudiante* 'no student', *varios estudiantes* 'several students'...)

(23) Numerals:

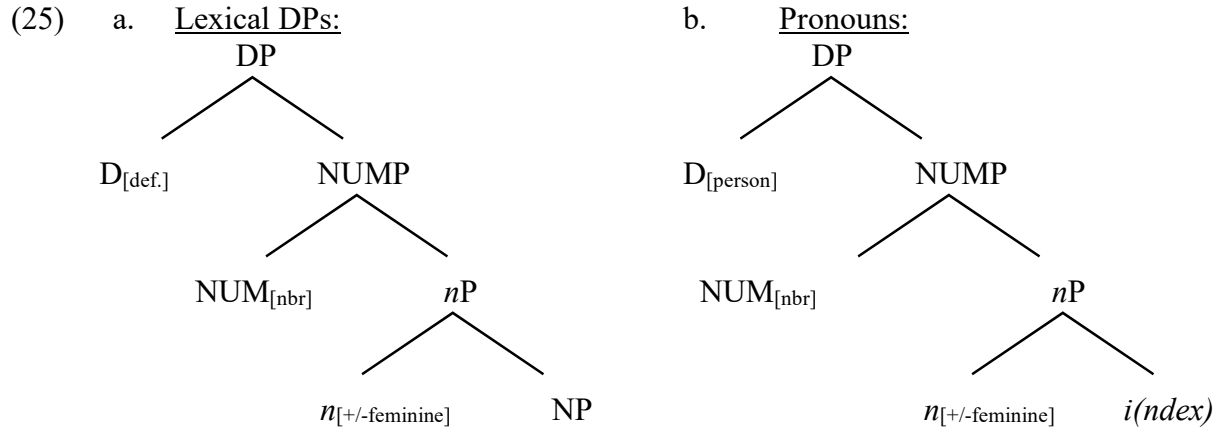
- Tres alumnos* llegaron tarde.  
three student.M.PL arrived late

(24) Non-specific DPs:

- El profesor* que contratemos puede ser hombre o mujer.  
the.M.SG professor.M.SG that hire.SUBJ.1PL can be.INF man or woman  
'The teacher we hire can be a man or a woman.'

An alternative to Harris' Human Cloning would consist in assuming that the gender system is also semantically marked for *female*, as proposed in Sauerland (2008b) or Percus (2006, 2011). With them, let's model this [female] property as a semantic presupposition. In the case of pronouns, the easiest way is to assume that pronouns contribute indexes for assignment functions and that ornamental inflectional features contribute partial identity functions for number, gender and person (Heim and Kratzer 1998, Heim 2008, Sauerland 2008b, Kratzer

2009). I will assume the same for lexical DPs, with the obvious adaptations (i.e., with some polymorphic action<sup>3</sup>). The following trees illustrate the basic syntactic analyses for lexical DPs and pronouns, respectively. As is standard, lexical DPs are extended projections of lexical nouns, whereas pronouns are analyzed as projecting a mere index at the lexical level and inflectional properties in its extended projections.



The different semantic realizations of the *n* head, i.e., the gender bearer, are provided below for both lexical DPs and pronouns:

- Semantic realizations of the *n* head:<sup>4</sup>
- (26) Lexical DPs:
- a.  $\llbracket +\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda f: \underline{\text{Female}}(x).f$
- b.  $\llbracket -\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda f.f$

<sup>3</sup> At least for *e* denoting DPs, polymorphism in the semantic type of the argument is avoided if gender is interpreted above the D head, as in Sauerland (2008b). I think that there are good reasons for not assuming this view, though (the behavior of gender under ellipsis being the most important one). In addition, I don't see good reasons to distribute gender in more than one position in the DP spine either, as in Yatsushiro and Sauerland (2006) or Pesetsky (2013). The reasons adduced in Yatsushiro and Sauerland for doing this are convincingly challenged in Adamson (2021). At any rate, polymorphism cannot be avoided whenever the DP denotations are not of the required type.

<sup>4</sup> For lexical DPs, it is not always clear whether the semantic contribution of gender is presuppositional or assertoric. Sudo and Spathas (2016, 2020) offer some interesting arguments to the effect of showing that noun classes in Greek are divided among those that encode both male and female meanings at the presuppositional and assertoric level, those in which only female contributes to the two levels, and those in which there is no gender meaning encoded at any level. The two main pieces of evidence come from nominal ellipsis and focus constructions. Nominal ellipsis has been used in previous literature also as an argument for introducing divisions among noun classes, although there is no consensus both regarding the grammatical status of many of the crucial cases and the theoretical implications we should derive from the relevant patterns (Zocca 2003, Bobaljik and Zocca 2010, Depiante and Masullo 2001, 2004, Saab 2004, 2008, 2010, Merchant 2014 and Ranero 2021). Sudo and Spathas, aware of the intricacies of the NP-ellipsis data, add focus constructions as an additional diagnostic to test the impact of gender at the presuppositional or the assertoric dimensions. I think that, applied to Spanish, the focus test would allow us to conclude that at least for some noun classes (e.g., the *tía/tío* 'aunt'/uncle' class) [female] must be part of what is asserted. So, if someone says *solo Ana es tía de Juan* 'Only Ana is Juan's aunt' the alternatives at play are all female ones, in a way such that from this sentence it is hard to infer that Pedro is not Juan's uncle. This is not observed in the masculine form in which [female] and [male] alternatives are calculated. In other classes, like the "teacher" one, the female meaning seems ambiguous, including sometimes only female alternatives. Yet, judgments are not clear or uniform across speakers. For the purposes of this paper, I will assume a presuppositional view of gender (probably, excluding proper names, as we will see), but I think that the main points to be made would also follow if some class noun asserts the gender meaning.



Pronouns:

The index:

- (27)  $\llbracket \langle e, n \rangle \rrbracket^g = \text{individual}$   
(e.g.,  $\llbracket \langle I, e \rangle \rrbracket^g = g(\llbracket \langle I, e \rangle \rrbracket)$ )

- (28) a.  $\llbracket +\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda x: \text{Female}(x). x$   
b.  $\llbracket -\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda x. x$

Evidence for semantically marking the feminine comes from usual (anti)-presupposition considerations (among many others, Heim 1991, Sauerland 2002, 2003, 2008a,b, Percus 2006, 2011, Chemla 2008). Assume first a simple version of *Maximize presupposition!*:

- (29) *Maximize presupposition!*: Among a set of alternatives, use the felicitous sentence with the strongest presupposition.

[Chemla 2008: 142]

Now, we say that two identical NPs or indexes that only differ in presuppositional force are alternatives. Therefore, given the context provided in (30), MP! dictates the use of the feminine form either for a lexical DP like in (30a) or a pronoun like in (30b):

- (30) [*context*: A group of female students decides to meet to do a final project to present the next class]
- a.  $\{\# \text{Los/las estudiantes}\}$  se encuentran en la casa de Anita.  
 $\{\text{the.M.PL/F.PL students}\}$  SE meet.3PL in the house of Anita  
'The students are meeting at Anita's house this Friday.'
- b.  $\{\# \text{Ellos/ellas}\}$  se encuentran en la casa de Anita.  
 $\{\text{they.M.PL / they.F.PL}\}$  SE meet.3PL in the house of Anita  
'They meet at Anita's house.'

When the context does not satisfy the presupposition, the "masculine", which anti-presupposes the feminine, must be used.

- (31) Plurals (for mixed groups):

- a. *Los niños* llegaron tarde.  
ART.M.PL child.M.PL arrived late  
'The children arrived late.'
- b. *Ellos* llegaron tarde.  
they.M.PL arrived late  
'They arrived late.'

- (32) Singular generics:

- Usualmente, *el niño* habla solo.  
usually ART.M.SG child.M.SG speaks alone.M.SG  
'Usually, the child speaks alone/to himself.'

On this view, there is no [male] feature in the system. A [female] presupposition on [+feminine] human nouns would be enough. Among other things, this predicts *dominance* effects

(Sauerland 2008b).<sup>5</sup> For instance, whenever a coordinate structure combines a masculine and feminine DPs predicative agreement shows up in the “masculine”:

- (33) Juan y Ana están cansados.  
 Juan and Ana are tired.M.PL  
 ‘Juan and Ana are tired.’

If one believes that the current system is semantically marked only for the [female] presupposition, then inclusive language (see (8)-(10)) impacts on representation in one particular direction. Concretely, the strategy enlarges our taxonomy including a semantic [male] presupposition which was absent in the system. This can be stated as follows:

- (34) Inclusive language #I: it converts an anti-presupposition into a semantic presupposition.

Here is one possible implementation. Assume that the current gender system is binary but unidimensional:

*Table 1: the current system (under one analysis)*

| System:<br>binary /unidimensional | Feminine in <i>-a</i> and variants | Masculine in <i>-o</i> and variants |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Feminine                          | +                                  | -                                   |

That the system is unidimensional concretely means that only the feminine dimension is encoded in the language.

- (35) Lexical DPs:  
 a.  $\llbracket +\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda f: \underline{\text{Female}}(x). f$   
 b.  $\llbracket -\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda f. f$

- (36) Pronouns:  
 a.  $\llbracket +\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda x: \underline{\text{Female}}(x). x$   
 b.  $\llbracket -\text{feminine} \rrbracket = \lambda x. x$

Under (34), the inclusive strategy consists of the conversion of a pragmatic reasoning (provided by MP!) into a purely semantic property. We can implement the idea by adding a new gender dimension to be encoded on *n*, as shown in the following table:

*Table 2: The “inclusive” gender system in Spanish*

| System:<br>binary<br>/bidimensional | Feminine in <i>-a</i><br>and variants | Masculine in <i>-o</i><br>and variants | Inclusive form<br>in <i>-e</i> | Predicted (not<br>attested?) <b>nota</b><br><b>al pie</b> |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Feminine                            | +                                     | -                                      | -                              | +                                                         |
| Masculine                           | -                                     | +                                      | -                              | +                                                         |

<sup>5</sup> Sauerland (2008b) gives other three tests to detect semantic markedness, which would also follow from *Maximize presupposition!*: (i) quantification, (ii) epistemic status, and (iii) emergence of the unmarked. I will not discuss the (non-)applicability of each of these tests in Spanish.

Focusing only on the three first slots in table 2, the relevant denotations for the  $n$  node would be as follows:<sup>6</sup>

- (37) Lexical DPs:
- a.  $\llbracket +F, -M \rrbracket = \lambda f: \underline{\text{Female}}(x). f$
  - b.  $\llbracket -F, +M \rrbracket = \lambda f: \underline{\text{Male}}(x). f$
  - c.  $\llbracket -F, -M \rrbracket = \lambda f. f$
- Pronouns:
- (38) a.  $\llbracket +F, -M \rrbracket = \lambda x: \underline{\text{Female}}(x). x$
- b.  $\llbracket -F, +M \rrbracket = \lambda x: \underline{\text{Male}}(x). x$
  - c.  $\llbracket -F, -M \rrbracket = \lambda x. x$

The consequence of this type of strategy is clear enough. Assuming that there is no [male] feature in the current system, we can conceive of the inclusive system as enlarging the gender taxonomy, by adding a [masculine] grammatical property associated to a semantic [male] presupposition. Enlarging the taxonomy in this way impacts on the distribution of the masculine/male forms, which are now semantically restricted to contexts which satisfy the male presupposition. For any binary system the calculus is very simple: power of base 2, that is:

- (39)  $2^n$  [where  $n$  stands for any dimension we would like to include]

Thus, the two systems under dispute are differentiated by the gender dimensions they offer, namely:

- (40) a. Current system:  $n = 1$  [dimensions = {feminine}]
- b. “Inclusive” system:  $n = 2$  [dimensions = {feminine, masculine}]
- and so on...

Evidently, enlarging social taxonomies rises many issues regarding to the problem of reintroducing stereotypes, the true borders of the taxonomy (e.g., all what the + in the LGBT...<sup>+</sup> implies), and, of course, its linguistic efficacy (see section 4). But before advancing into this type of considerations, further empirical discussion is needed, since the picture of the gender system offered so far is too simplistic. In effect, as already noted by Percus (2006), there are cases in which the “masculine” form triggers a stronger meaning than the predicted by a mere anti-presupposition. In the example below, the masculine form, more than anti-presupposing the female meaning (i.e., that the speaker does not believe that the referent is female), strongly suggests that the individual is not female:

- (41) A: No sé si el nuevo profesor que van  
not know.1SG if the new professor.M.SG that go.3PL  
a contratar es hombre o mujer.  
to hire.INF is man or woman  
‘I don’t know whether the new professor that they will hire is a man or a woman.’
- B: #Yo tampoco. Todavía no hablé con él.  
I neither still not talk.PST.1SG with he  
‘Me neither. I haven’t talked to him yet.’

<sup>6</sup> Again, in the case of lexical DPs what could be under dispute is part of an asserted meaning, not a presupposition. In either case, it is still a representational dispute.

This type of facts casts doubts on any attempt to derive the strong masculine meaning by adding more conditions on (anti-)presuppositions (say, ways of introducing further epistemic conditions like in Chemla 2008 and others). In simple cases, like *él vino* ‘he came’, in which there is something else than a mere feminine anti-presupposition, you can indeed derive the stronger male meaning from inferences coming from competence and authority assumptions.<sup>7</sup> Simplifying, we can assume that in cases like this the speaker is opinionated with respect to the feminine presupposition, in such a way that whenever she asserts that *él vino* we derive that she believes that *p* is not the case. Now, this analysis does not extend to uncertainty contexts like (41), in which Speaker B is clearly not opinionated, without further assumptions.<sup>8</sup>

In addition, note the sharp contrast between singular and plural pronouns, which do behave as predicted under an (anti-)presuppositional analysis.

- (42) A: No sé si los nuevos profesores que van  
not know.1SG if the new professor.M.PL that go.3PL  
a contratar son hombres o mujeres.  
to hire.INF are men or women  
‘I don’t know whether the new professor that they will hire is man or woman.’  
B: Yo tampoco. Todavía no hablé con ellos.  
I neither still not talk.PST.1SG with they.M.PL  
‘Me neither. I haven’t talked to them yet.’

This shows that there is not a distinction between lexical DPs *vs.* pronouns (as suggested by Percus): plural pronouns, like lexical DPs, can be unrestricted.

But there is more. Not all singular pronoun triggers the strong male meaning. Pronominal clitics don’t always give rise to the strong meaning that the individual is not female.

- (43) A: No sé si el nuevo profesor que van  
not know.1SG if the new professor.M.SG that go.3PL  
a contratar es hombre o mujer.  
to hire.INF is man or woman  
‘I don’t know whether the new professor that they will hire is a man or a woman.’  
B: Yo tampoco. Todavía no lo vi.  
I neither still not CL.ACC.M.3SG saw.1SG  
‘Me neither. I haven’t seen him yet.’

<sup>7</sup> The competence assumption states that the speaker is opinionated with respect to some presupposed proposition *p* such as she believes that *p* is true, or she believes that it is not ( $[B_s[p] \vee B_s[\neg p]]$ ). Chemla (2008) supplements competence with an additional authority assumption (i.e., that the speaker believes that she is an authority on *p*) to account for presuppositional failures which are not particularly relevant for the present purposes.

<sup>8</sup> As Percus shows, this is not the case with “true” anti-presuppositions. For the well-known *to know/to think* pair, dropping competence and authority assumptions is enough to force a weak inference in *to think* that the speaker does not believe that Mary is pregnant. Compare with *his*, which in the same uncertain environment, still triggers the stronger meaning that the referent is not female:

- (i) a. A. I don’t know whether Mary is pregnant or not.  
B. I don’t either. Jane thinks she is.  
b. A. I can’t tell from here whether that professor is a man or a woman.  
B. I can’t either. ?Mary was decorating his office. Let’s ask her.

[Percus 2006]

Following ideas in Cardinaletti and Starke (1999), we can make sense of the contrast between (41) and (43) by assuming that clitics are semantically impoverished when compared to strong pronouns like *él*. Concretely, clitics do not encode [human] and, consequently, any sex feature, male or female, but only gender. So, the masculine you see in the example is a pure formal gender feature. Under this assumption, there is no expectation that the impoverished clitic triggers any male presupposition/meaning here.

In sum, the formal makeup of pronouns matters when it comes to deriving their presuppositional behavior. And it matters in two ways: (i) their number encoding is relevant, (ii) their clitic or strong nature is relevant, as well.

A plausible solution inspired in Percus (2006) would be to assume that Spanish uses both [male] and [female] presuppositions. A syntactic-semantic gender feature is added under specific conditions. For instance, we can adopt some form of restricted Human Cloning according to which a semantic gender feature is added on *n* in the syntax in some specific environments.

- (44) Restricted Human Cloning (tentative):<sup>9</sup> If  $[n_{[hum]}(+Root)]$  projects an atomic and individual-denoting DP, then,  
 $[n_{[hum]}(+Root)] \rightarrow [n_{[hum, \{[male], [female]\}]}(+Root)]$

From an abstract point of view, each of the syntactic representations in (45) would trigger restricted HC:

- (45) a. Lexical DPs:
- 
- b. Pronouns:
- 

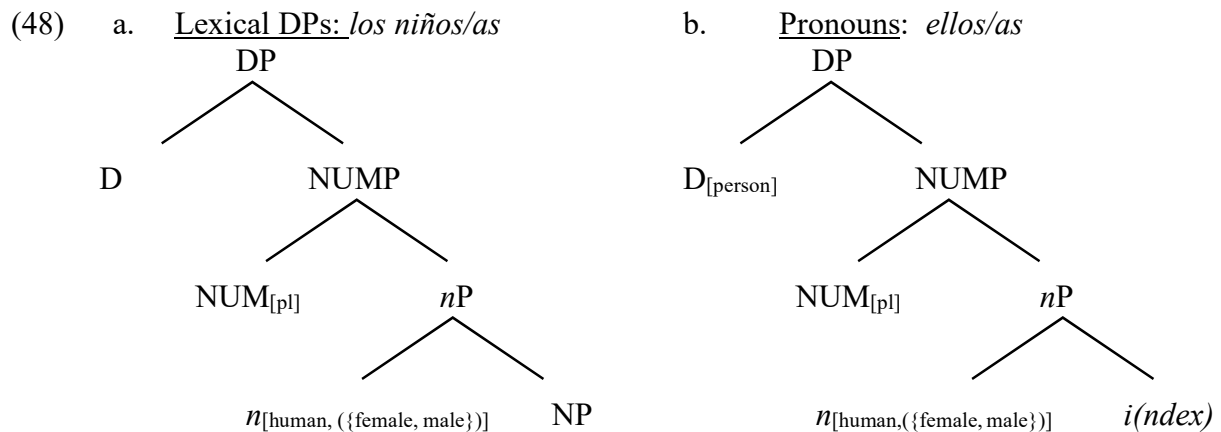
I think that this describes well most uses (but there are remaining issues, in particular, with definite descriptions, see footnote 9), provided, of course, that something along the lines of Human Gender applies (see (17a)):

- (46) Human gender:  
 ‘female’  $\rightarrow$  [+fem] / [\_\_\_\_, ‘human’]  
 [-fem] / elsewhere

<sup>9</sup> I would like to insist in the tentative nature of this formulation. For instance, it is not clear at all that this captures the behavior of gender with singular generics or with some definite descriptions without further commitments with respect to the semantics of generics or definite descriptions. Alternatively, we can think of [sex] features as being determined by purely formal properties of DPs and not by semantic ones.

For instance, whenever D is a non-human clitic, a generalized quantifier or a plural DP, sex-assignment is left open giving rise to the unmarked case.<sup>10</sup> Consider the case of plural DPs/pronouns:

- (47) a. *Los niños llegaron tarde.*  
 ART.M.PL child.M.PL arrived late  
 ‘The children arrived late.’  
 b. *Ellos llegaron tarde.*  
 they.M.PL arrived late  
 ‘They arrived late.’



So, in the plural, adding a sex feature is entirely optional, leaving open the possibility that *n* does not encode any sex feature, but only a human one. This, together with Human Gender in (46), basically gives us Percus’ story.

Semantic realizations of the *n* head:

- (49) Lexical DPs:  
 a.  $\llbracket \text{female} \rrbracket = \lambda f: \underline{\text{Female}}(x). f$   
 b.  $\llbracket \text{male} \rrbracket = \lambda f: \underline{\text{Male}}(x). f$   
 c.  $\llbracket \text{human} \rrbracket = \lambda f: \underline{\text{Human}}(x). f$   
Pronouns:  
The index:  
 (50)  $\llbracket \langle e, n \rangle \rrbracket^g = \text{individual}$   
 (e.g.,  $\llbracket \langle I, e \rangle \rrbracket^g = g(\llbracket \langle I, e \rangle \rrbracket)$ )  
 (51) a.  $\llbracket \text{female} \rrbracket = \lambda x: \underline{\text{Female}}(x). x$   
 b.  $\llbracket \text{male} \rrbracket = \lambda x: \underline{\text{Male}}(x). x$   
 c.  $\llbracket \text{human} \rrbracket = \lambda x: \underline{\text{Human}}(x). x$

In sum, it seems that the Spanish gender system uses a [male] feature. Its distribution is extremely complex and not easy to state, but there are a set of indubitable cases in which the

<sup>10</sup> Or it is human ‘honoris causa’. Suppose that you see a nice cat and pointing out to it, you say:

- (i) *Mirá ese gato!*  
 look that cat.M.SG  
 ‘Look at that cat.’

In such a situation, the noun *gato*, although marked as masculine, does not trigger the [male] meaning, which is the case when you replace *gato* by *niño* ‘child’.

feature is both syntactically and semantically active. Pure anti-presuppositional inferences are still playing a role in the system, but only in those cases in which Restricted Human Cloning does not apply and the *n* head can be left with no sex feature. This is the case for non-atomic DPs/pronouns or non-human ones.

## 2.2. Additional evidence for a [male] feature: proper names

Recent findings by Mussini (2024, 2025) indirectly confirm the existence of a [male] feature in the Spanish gender system. The evidence has to do with the behavior of proper names in predicative uses. As Mussini shows, predicative uses of proper names do not pass markedness tests, showing that proper names must be marked either for female or male. Consider the case of *Alejandro.M* / *Alejandra.F* (but the test applies to *all* proper names). The following examples are adapted from Mussini's work:

### (52) No mixed readings:

|          |              |          |        |
|----------|--------------|----------|--------|
| Los      | Alejandro(s) | llegaron | tarde. |
| the.M.PL | Alejandros   | arrived  | late   |

'The Alejandros (all men) arrived late.'

### (53) No female interpretation in generic environments:

|        |    |           |     |         |       |    |            |
|--------|----|-----------|-----|---------|-------|----|------------|
| Cuando | un | Alejandro | te  | engaña, | nunca | lo | olvidás.   |
| when   | an | Alejandro | you | cheats  | never | it | forget.2SG |

'When an Alejandro (only men) cheats you, you never forget it.'

For the case in which there is no plural marking, one could argue that there is an underlyingly metalinguistic structure more or less along the following lines:

### (54) los x+/alexándro/

Given that all (or most) people called /alexándro/ is male, it seems that we don't need the postulation of a [male] feature here. Yet, things are not so easy when we consider the string with the plural marking. In any case, let us assume that a metalinguistic derivation is also possible here.

### (55) los x+/alexándro/+s

There are other cases to consider, though. In my Spanish, you can shorten *Alejandro* and *Alejandra* to produce two homonyms:

- (56) a. Alejandro → Ale  
b. Alejandra → Ale

However, the shortening does not change the basic patterns; in (57) and (58) the plural masculine proper name still triggers the strong [male] reading:

### (57) No mixed readings:

|          |        |          |        |
|----------|--------|----------|--------|
| Los      | Ale(s) | llegaron | tarde. |
| the.M.PL | Ale(s) | arrived  | late   |

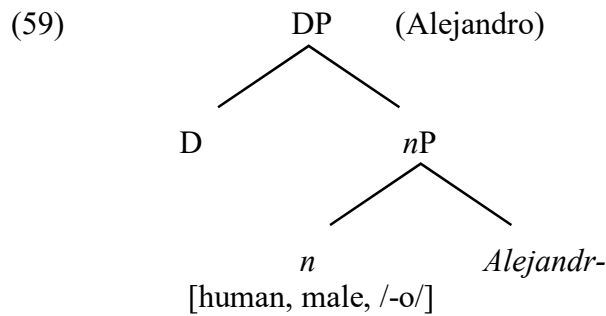
'The Ales (all men) arrived late.'

### (58) No female interpretation in generic environments:

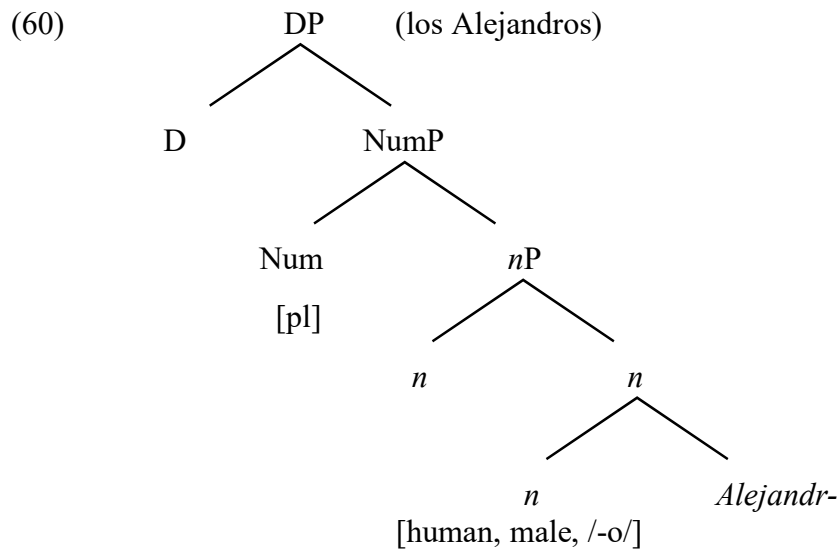
|        |         |     |     |         |       |    |            |
|--------|---------|-----|-----|---------|-------|----|------------|
| Cuando | un      | Ale | te  | engaña, | nunca | lo | olvidás.   |
| when   | an.M.PL | Ale | you | cheats  | never | it | forget.2SG |

‘When an Ale (only men) cheats you, you never forget it.’

Assuming that proper names are born as atomic and individual denoting entities, Restricted Human Cloning applies, giving rise to male or female proper names. Following Saab and Lo Guercio (2020)’s idea that proper names do not project number (the category that turns entities into properties), the basic structure of a referential proper name can be represented as follows:



In predicative uses, however, there is also the presence of an empty *n* which ultimately allows for the proper name to occur in predicative environments (see Saab and Lo Guercio 2020):



Now, since Restricted Human Cloning is calculated at the first categorizing head, a [male] feature is inserted here regardless of additional nominal and functional projections. This blocks any attempt to leave lower *n* unmarked for sex and explains why there are not mixed or non-sexual readings in the relevant examples in (52), (53), (57) and (58).<sup>11</sup>

### 3. Giving up Human Cloning

Putting the details of analytical options aside, the system just sketched still gives rise to some form of heteronormative taxonomy (at least, you can infer it). Consider a revised version of (4) after restricted Human Cloning:

<sup>11</sup> Following Sudo and Spathas’s (2020) analysis for some noun classes in Greek, Mussini (2025) proposes that in predicative uses the best way of modeling the [male/female] features is by encoding them at the assertoric level at the *n* node (this is not their solution for Greek, but this is irrelevant).



- (61) The heteronormative taxonomy relativized:  
[human] / in the context of an atomic entity  

```
graph TD; A["[human] / in the context of an atomic entity"] --- B["[male]"]; A --- C["[female]"]
```

  
[male]                      [female]  
  
[I.e., human nouns under certain conditions are either male or female]

Taking for granted that something along these lines is what derives the heteronormative taxonomy, we can now address *Q2*:

(Q2) What exactly does the inclusive linguistic behavior consist of?

As stated in (13), I claim that the strategy roughly corresponds to a representational counterpart of expressive manipulation in Corver's sense:

- (62) Thesis: Inclusive language is a concrete instance of expressive manipulation in Corver's (2016) sense (i.e., deviation from rules of grammar). Yet, unlike Corver's expectations, grammatical deviation in this case impacts on representation (connected to propositional/thought systems).

In this section, first, I provide some background on expressive manipulation in the framework put forward by Corver (2016) and then, I argue that representational meanings can also be manipulated. In the specific case of the gender system, the grammatical apparatus is manipulated in a way such to change certain semantic presuppositions.

### 3.1. Expressivity and grammatical markedness

The linguistic importance of expressivity has been always under suspicion, both in the linguistic and in the analytic philosophy traditions. In linguistics, even for those who adopted Bühler's triangle, e.g., some of the Prague School members, representation/ideation is the primary function of language. Put differently, language is first designed as representational device, as stated in the following conjecture:

- (63) The representation-first conjecture (RF-conjecture): language is mainly a representational system.

On this view, expression/emotion is subsidiary of representation. One way to understand this subsidiary character is assuming that expression requires complication of the representational device. Pos (1934) put the idea clearly:

“I believe that, in order to understand the emotive dimension in a linguistic perspective, one has to base oneself on language conceived as an instrument for reasoning. On this basis, affective meaning would appear to be a complication of rational language.”

[Pos 1934: 138]

Corver (2016) is a contemporary, radical implementation of Pos' idea. Concretely, he assumes that emotion is read by the appraisal systems through information available or deduced from

1. Space-based indexing: a symbol (e.g., a functional category) indexes a high amount of information and high distinguishability if it is in a deviant (marked) position in a linguistic representation.

3. Indexation by duplication: a symbol (e.g., a suffix or a phonological feature) ‘spreads out’ across a linguistic expression and this way indexes a high amount of information and high distinguishability.

The following three examples illustrates each indexation type in Dutch:

- In (64a), the singular indefinite *een* combines with the plural *boeken* in a putative violation of agreement and selection rules. The expressive effects of this type of syntactic deviation connect to the exclamatory force of the entire sentence. In (64b), a neuter demonstrative is used to express a pejorative attitude to its referent. Finally, spreading the *-e* morpheme in the modifiers of *auto* in (64c) contributes an intensification meaning. Elsewhere, I have argued that Corver's view is too radical and probably incorrect in many particular cases, in which, in reality, putative syntactic deviation is derived by regular syntax once proper analyses are provided (AUTHOR). At a more general level, I have doubts about the idea that constructions that are conventional in all respects (e.g., Romance binominals like *el gallina de Andrés* 'the chicken of Andrés' for which an analysis along Corver's lines could be plausible at first sight) can be linked to mechanisms of perceptual alteration. Put differently, attested expressive constructions, although marked in many interesting ways, are part of conventional grammar and not "verbal art". Yet, there are also linguistic phenomena that seem to fit Corver's expectation, at least partially. Inclusive gender is one of those phenomena. Concretely, inclusive language in

Spanish could be a concrete instance of space and symbol-based grammatical deviation, as explained in the next section.<sup>12</sup>

### 3.2. Subverting the heteronormative taxonomy by expressive means

Considering again the inclusive paradigm in (8)-(10), repeated below, and the relevant examples in (68) and (69):

- One of the proposed “inclusive” gender systems:
- (65) human nouns:
- |                       |                       |                                      |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------------|
| a. niño ‘child.M.SG’  | b. niña ‘child.F.SG’  | c. <u>niñe</u> ‘ART.INCLUSIVE.SG’    |
| d. niños ‘child.M.PL’ | e. niñas ‘child.F.PL’ | f. <u>niñes</u> ‘child.INCLUSIVE.PL’ |
- (66) definite articles:
- |                   |                   |                                  |
|-------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|
| a. el ‘ART.M.SG’  | b. la ‘ART.F.SG’  | c. <u>le</u> ‘ART.INCLUSIVE.SG’  |
| d. los ‘ART.M.PL’ | e. las ‘ART.F.PL’ | d. <u>les</u> ‘ART.INCLUSIVE.PL’ |
- (67) personal pronouns
- |                      |                      |                                   |
|----------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------|
| a. él ‘he’           | b. ella ‘she’        | c. <u>elle</u> ‘PR.INCLUSIVE.SG’  |
| d. ellos ‘they.M.PL’ | e. ellas ‘they.M.PL’ | f. <u>elles</u> ‘PR.INCLUSIVE.PL’ |
- (68) Plurals (for mixed groups):
- |    |                                          |                 |                 |               |
|----|------------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|---------------|
| a. | <i>Les</i>                               | <i>niñes</i>    | <i>llegaron</i> | <i>tarde.</i> |
|    | ART.INCL.PL                              | child.INCL.PL   | arrived         | late          |
|    | ‘The children (no gender) arrived late.’ |                 |                 |               |
| b. | <i>Elles</i>                             | <i>llegaron</i> | <i>tarde.</i>   |               |
|    | they.INCL.PL                             | arrived         | late            |               |
|    | ‘They arrived late.’                     |                 |                 |               |
- (69) Singular generics:
- |                                               |             |               |                      |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------------|---------------|----------------------|
| Usualmente, <i>le</i>                         | <i>niñe</i> | <i>habla</i>  | <i>sole.</i>         |
| usually                                       | ART.INCL.SG | child.INCL.SG | speaks alone.INCL.SG |
| ‘Usually, the child speaks alone/to himself.’ |             |               |                      |

Now, the linguistic significance of this form of linguistic manipulation largely depends on the proper analysis of the current gender system. In section 2, I have raised the possibility that Percus (2006) is right in the sense that the current system already makes use of a [male] feature, modeled as a semantic presupposition:

- Semantic realizations of the *n* head:
- (70) Lexical DPs:
- |                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| a. $\llbracket \text{female} \rrbracket = \lambda f. \text{Female}(x).f$ |
| b. $\llbracket \text{male} \rrbracket = \lambda f. \text{Male}(x).f$     |
| c. $\llbracket \text{human} \rrbracket = \lambda f. \text{Human}(x).f$   |
- Pronouns:
- The index:
- (71)  $\llbracket \langle e, n \rangle \rrbracket^g = \text{individual}$   
(e.g.,  $\llbracket \langle I, e \rangle \rrbracket^g = g(\llbracket \langle I, e \rangle \rrbracket)$ )

<sup>12</sup> For discussion on the grammatical status of inclusive gender in Spanish, see Fábregas (2022) and Muñoz Pérez (2023).

- (72) a.  $\llbracket \text{female} \rrbracket = \lambda x: \text{Female}(x). x$   
 b.  $\llbracket \text{male} \rrbracket = \lambda x: \text{Male}(x). x$   
 c.  $\llbracket \text{human} \rrbracket = \lambda x. \text{Human}(x). x$

If this is the right analysis, the inclusive strategy would consist of something along the following lines (cfr. (34) above):

- (73) Inclusive language #2: it creates new anti-presuppositions by giving up some forced presuppositions.

This can be straightforwardly implemented by abandoning any form of Human Cloning, repeated in (74) below:

- (74) Restricted Human Cloning: If  $[n_{\text{hum}}(+\text{Root})]$  projects an atomic and individual-denoting DP, then,  
 $[n_{\text{hum}}(+\text{Root})] \rightarrow [n_{\text{hum}, \{\text{male}, \text{female}\}}(+\text{Root})]$

Giving up Restricted Human Cloning amounts to the new taxonomy in (14), repeated as (75):

- (75) The new taxonomy (a plausible description):  

$$\begin{array}{c} \text{[human]} \\ \swarrow \quad \searrow \\ \text{([male])} \quad \text{([female])} \end{array}$$
 [I.e., you don't need associate human nouns to [male] or [female]]

But this is not enough yet. As it stands, the system produces more unmarked uses of the masculine forms, since now,

- (76) Él      llegó    tarde.  
          he      arrived late  
          'He arrived late.'

should be able to give the weak inference that it is not the case that the speaker believes that the individual being referred to by this use of the pronoun is female, a clearly incorrect prediction. Therefore, in order to get true "inclusive" effects, syncretism in the set of realizational rules must be avoided, as well. We can still have a binary gender system with [+feminine] being partially predictable, i.e., we still have Human Gender:

- (77) Human Gender:  
       'female'  $\rightarrow$  [+fem] / [\_\_\_\_, 'human']  
                   [-fem] / elsewhere

But now, syncretism is blocked by adding a new vocabulary item:

- Simplified and incomplete lexical insertion rules [e.g., reference to class is avoided]:  
 (78) [+fem]  $\leftrightarrow$  /-a/  
       [-fem]  $\leftrightarrow$  /-o/ / \_\_\_\_ [male, human]  
       [-fem]  $\leftrightarrow$  /-e/ / \_\_\_\_ [human]

The new system gives rise to the emergence of the unmarked through the new morpheme vocabulary item *-e*. The new unmarked form behaves as expected regarding dominance. Compare (33) with (79):

- (79) Juan y Ana están cansades.  
 Juan and Ana are tired.INCL.PL  
 ‘Juan and Ana are tired.’

Interestingly, the new system also predicts well-behaved weak and strong inferences, depending, for instance, on epistemic assumptions. Consider the following example:

- (80) Elle/le chique está jugando.  
*pron*.INCL.3SG/the. INCL.SG is playing  
 ‘They/the child is playing.’

For the pronominal case, *elle está jugando*, the inclusive morpheme triggers weak and strong inferences as expected. In polite or uncertainty environments, the relevant inferences deriving from the alternatives constructed out from (72) can be put in prose as follows:

- (81) Weak inference (the polite/uncertainty inference):  
 a. It is not the case that the speaker believes that the individual being referred by this use of the pronoun is female.  
 b. It is not the case that the speaker believes that the individual being referred by this use of the pronoun is male.

A strong, non-binary inference can be also obtained whenever the speaker is strongly opinionated, in a way such that in uttering the relevant sentence the speaker believes that the referent of the pronoun is not male and is not female:

- (82) Strong inference (the non-binary inference):  
 a. The speaker believes that the individual being referred by this use of the pronoun is not female.  
 b. The speaker believes that the individual being referred by this use of the pronoun is not male.

Now, the introduction of the *-e* morpheme into the system not only impacts on truth-conditions but also on pure expressive meanings. It is well-known that the use of *-e* also gives us a contextual profile of the speaker. This is consistent with Corver’s original thesis that grammatical manipulation must impact on expressivity. According to him, grammatical manipulation affects the appraisal system in which subjective valences are encoded and computed. Yet, I think that there are more than mere valences in this case. A felicitous use of the inclusive strategy also imparts information with respect certain cultural/ideological settings which the speaker ascribes to. This type of expressive meaning can then be better modeled as a propositional object in a way similar to Kaplan (1999) (for related use-conditional approaches, see Potts 2005, McCready 2010, Predelli 2013, Gutzmann 2015, 2019). For convenience, I assume that use-conditions can be stated as a conventional bias on words/morphemes (but there are many alternatives). Using the notational device in McCready (2010) for mixed items, I assume that *-e* is a mixed morpheme denoting the human property at the at-issue dimension and a certain gender bias at the expressive dimension:

(83)  $\llbracket -e, \text{human} \rrbracket = \lambda f. \underline{\text{Human}(x)}.f \blacklozenge \text{gender bias}$

The gender bias for *-e* can be roughly in the following terms (see Predelli 2013 and Orlanda and Saab 2020):

(84) *Bias for ‘-e’*:  $c \in CU(-e)$  only if, in  $c$ ,  $c_a$  is a participant in a context  $c$  in which the heteronormative taxonomy is under dispute

On this view, the inclusive strategy creates a new expressive morpheme, more specifically, a mixed one, in which both representation and expression is affected.

## 4. Final remarks

### 4.1. Summary

I started this study offering three questions regarding the current gender system and its alternative inclusive strategy:

(Q1) Is the Spanish gender system (representationally) biased?

[I.e., in the sense of placing the speaker into a particular (gender-biased / oppressive) *cultural / ideological dimension* (in the Bajtinian’s sense)?]

(Q2) What exactly does the inclusive linguistic behavior consist of?

(Q3) How is the heteronormative taxonomy derived in the current gender system?

As already noted in the introduction, Q1 does not have a conclusive answer. Although it is true that the system allows us to licitly infer a certain heteronormative taxonomy (recall (4)), there is no direct connection between the taxonomies that can be inferred from particular languages and our knowledge systems. For instance, the biological taxonomies that one can infer from the entire gender system in Spanish contradicts our biological knowledge. To see this, consider the basic fact that most animals are not subject to Human Cloning, even when they have biological sex. Put differently, the taxonomies that can be inferred from grammatical systems do not seem to have an obvious impact on our knowledge systems. Yet, they can have an impact on our cultural profiles by, for instance, reenforcing unwanted stereotypes. Inclusive gender is a attempt to put those stereotypical taxonomies under dispute. I claim that, from a linguistic perspective, the strategy implies the abandonment of any form of Human Cloning, and consequently, eliminating the unwanted heteronormative duality that follows from such a rule for human nouns. This answers (at least partially) Q2. In order to eliminate Human Cloning from the system, one must also manipulate the set of abstract morphemes and realizational rules that allow to make the abandonment of Human Cloning explicit enough. This is what the introduction of the morpheme *-e*, which realizes [human] *ns*, exactly does. Now, such an introduction also impacts on the expressive dimension of language by adding a gender bias in that dimension (see (83)), forcing us to analyze the inclusive morpheme as mixed term.

There are many remaining issues, mostly related to Q3. Even with some caveats, I have assumed a presuppositional analysis of grammatical gender. I think that this is correct for pronouns, but much more controversial for some noun classes. As shown in section 2.2, there are good reasons to believe that gender in proper nouns is assertoric in Spanish, as suggested in Mussini (2025), and according to Sudo and Spathas (2016, 2020) for certain noun classes in Greek (see footnote 4). If this is correct, and some noun classes have assertoric gender, then a

more complex analysis would have to make the proper distinctions. In terms of semantic calculations, an assertoric analysis would also use alternatives to generate relevant scalar implicatures. I will leave this open for further research.

But there is more. I have assumed a neo-Gricean approach to anti-presupposition with no discussion of more grammatical alternatives (see Chierchia *et al* 2013 for an excellent overview). For instance, Elliott and Sauerland (2019) suggests that some form of inclusive gender in English (in particular, the use of *they/them/themselves* instead of *he/him/himself* in inclusive contexts) could be derived through proper manipulations of an Exhaustive operator. I think that an implementation in terms of Exh is plausible and perhaps advisable, but it is to a certain extent orthogonal to the aims of the present study.<sup>13</sup>

Finally, more in-depth revision could arise from some recent experimental results that show that Gricean reasonings can be blocked by stereotypical roles in gender resolution (Pozniak and Burnett 2021, Stetie and Zunino 2022 and Anaya-Ramírez *et al* 2022).

#### 4.2. Enlarging contexts of use: a brief remark about slur reclamation

I would like to conclude these considerations on the morphosemantics of inclusive gender by comparing this strategy with another strategy of linguistic intervention, namely, slur reappropriation, i.e., the use of slur words by members of the target of derogation (for a recent proposal and references, see Carranza and Lo Guercio 2024). Here is a nice example of slur reappropriation in Rioplatense Spanish, in which the phrase *Puto Peronista* ('F... Peronist', very hard to translate with all its local coloring) is reappropriated together with other sexual slurs:

"Los Putos Peronistas nacimos como agrupación a fines de 2007 en el kilómetro 35 de ruta 3, en las afueras de González Catán, partido de La Matanza y desde allí nos ampliamos al resto del conurbano, a la Capital, a Neuquén, a Mendoza, y a otros rincones de nuestra patria.

*Somos tortas, trans, travestis y putos y también somos hermanas, hijos, padres y madres. Somos trabajadores, desocupadas, estudiantes. Somos los que construyen la riqueza de la Nación. Somos hijxs del deseo y deseamos una nación de hermandad: justa, libre y soberana.*

Los Putos Peronistas somos hijos políticos de estos años, en los que la política como sueño y promesa para cambiar este sistema social injusto vuelve a ocupar el centro de la escena -a pesar de la mala leche y los manoseos de los

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<sup>13</sup> In addition, it is worth mentioning that the ways in which I have characterized semantic markedness in gender was simplistic in many respects. For instance, as noted by Ramiro Caso (pers. comm.) another way to look to the (at least some of the) "unwanted rules" (see (18)) would be to impose different quantificational force for the [female] and the [male] presuppositions. As before, the [female] presupposition would exhaust the domain of individuals, as shown in (ia), whereas the [male] presupposition would only require that the intersection between the set of male individuals and whatever the set *f* stands for not be empty, as shown in (ib). Similar considerations would generalize to pronouns with the corresponding adaptations.

- (i) Lexical DPs:  
 a.  $\llbracket \text{female} \rrbracket = \lambda f. \text{Female}(x). f$   
 b.  $\llbracket \text{male} \rrbracket = \lambda f. \text{Male}(x) \cap f(x) \neq \emptyset. f$

This also derives markedness effects for gender once number is properly calculated. Thus, for a mixed plural reading (e.g., *los chicos*), the presupposition is met to the extent that at least one individual in the domain is male. For the singular, we will have a unique individual into the domain, so the presupposition is met only if such an individual is male. Of course, things are more complex in the case of definite descriptions depending on grammatical and semantic-pragmatic constraints. For instance, in uncertainty environments like (43), (ib) does not give good results without further assumptions on the semantics of DPs.

medios de comunicación masivos contra un gobierno al que sentimos nuestro- y en los que lxs trabajadores podemos comer más tranquilos y empezar a pensar en la educación, la salud, la vivienda y por qué no en la diversidad sexual de nuestros iguales argentinxs. Son tiempos de recuperar las banderas de Perón y Evita por una patria políticamente soberana, independiente económicamente y socialmente justa.

Porque el peronismo es el hecho maldito del país burgués, también seremos nosotrxs la chispa que permita a nuestra comunidad expulsar hasta sus últimos vestigios discriminatorios.”

[<https://web.archive.org/web/20100703021728/http://www.putos-peronistas.com.ar/about>]

“The Putos Peronistas (F... Peronist) were born as a group at the end of 2007 at kilometer 35 of route 3, on the outskirts of González Catán, La Matanza district and from there we expanded to the rest of the suburbs, to the Capital, to Neuquén, to Mendoza, and to other corners of our country.

We are tortas (d...), trans, travestis and putos (f...) and we are also sisters, children, fathers and mothers. We are workers, unemployed, students. We are the ones who build the wealth of the Nation. We are children of desire and we desire a nation of brotherhood: fair, free and sovereign.

The Putos Peronistas are political children of these years, in which politics as a dream and promise to change this unjust social system once again occupies the center of the scene - despite the bad temper and the manipulations of the mass media against a government that we feel is ours - and in which we workers can eat more peacefully and begin to think about education, health, housing and why not about the sexual diversity of our Argentinian peers. These are times to recover the flags of Perón and Evita for a politically sovereign, economically independent and socially just homeland.

Because Peronism is the cursed fact of the bourgeois country, we will also be the spark that allows our community to expel even its last discriminatory vestiges.”

I would like to suggest that reappropriation looks for an impact on use-conditions in Kaplan and others’ sense. Compared to the inclusive strategy, it is also a form of linguistic manipulation, but a purely semantic-pragmatic one. Essentially, it consists of the explicit intention of enlarging contexts of felicitous use for conventionally implicated meanings. In this sense, it is the perfect opposite to inclusive language, which, among other things, marks masculine with the aim of reducing its contexts of use.

Following Orlando and Saab (2020), I assume that a slur like *sudaca* ‘South-American.PEJ’ can be analyzed as denoting the following bias (in Predelli’s 2013 terms):

(85) *Bias for ‘sudaca’*:  $c \in CU(sudaca)$  only if, in  $c$ ,  $c_a$  is a participant in a context  $c$  in which a stereotype about South-Americans is in force in  $c$

Now, stereotypes introduce belief systems, perhaps, sets of propositions. Adapting Kratzer’s idea about modal basis, we can think of stereotypes as cultural basis (briefly, misleading and typifying theories about things, among which there are social groups):

(86)  $[[\text{Stereotype}]]^{g,w} = \lambda p. \exists P_{\langle e,t \rangle} [P \in C \ \& \ p = [\lambda w. P(\text{Kind})(w)]]$

Consider now our previous reappropriation example. Compared to the inclusive strategy reappropriation is simpler in many respects. First, as I already said, it consists of a linguistic intervention with the aim of altering/impacting on conditions of use. In this sense, there is no expressive grammar involved in Corver’s sense. Second, and most importantly, reappropriation is a proposal for enlarging contexts of use in a way such as introducing at least more contexts of use, which essentially dispute stereotypes as encoded through (85) and (86). Consequently, if successful, it has an obvious anti-bias or re-bias effect. Put differently, it disputes felicity conditions by merely manipulating the expressive meaning of slur words. Finally, unlike the



inclusive strategy, it does not change social taxonomies by imposing new ones; quite the opposite, it puts under question its existence and social utility. In a sense, it makes visible the irrational character of social taxonomies, by unveiling a crucial representational failure (see Losada 2021).

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